Teacher Training Guide

How to teach each phase, and how to run the games, trivia, spelling and memory work. Read this before your first Sunday. Plan on about 30 minutes, ideally with the other volunteers at a training lunch.

Part 1: Your Job in One Sentence

> **Help kids see that the Bible is one true story about God's love that leads to Jesus, and make it so fun they want to come back.**

You do not need to be a Bible scholar. Every phase file gives you background notes, a ready-to-read story script, questions and answers. Your job is to **prepare, love the kids, and keep it simple.**

Part 2: How to Prepare Each Phase (Monthly)

About two weeks before the month starts:

1. **Read the phase file** from top to bottom (about 45 minutes).
2. **Read the Bible books yourself.** At least read the passages for the four weekly stories. Bonus: watch the @bibleproject "Overview" video for each book in the phase. It is the fastest way to understand a book's big picture.
3. **Preview every video.** Use the search links in the phase file and pick the version you'll show. Write down the exact title and copy the link into your notes. Check that it fits your time slot and your kids.
4. **Make or print supplies.** Check the phase's games and crafts, and print the printables for the phase.
5. **Learn the song.** Practice the cumulative book song and motions until you can lead it without notes. Kids will copy your energy.
6. **Send the Take-Home Family Page** (the last section of every phase file) to parents in Week 1.

Each week (Saturday night or before class):

- Re-read that week's story script out loud once.
- Set up the room: chairs or carpet squares, video ready, game supplies, craft station.
- Pray for each child by name.

Part 3: How to Teach a Bible Story (Any Age)

The "HOOK → BOOK → LOOK → TOOK" method

Step	What you do	Time
HOOK	Grab attention with an object lesson, question or surprise (in every phase file)	2–3 min
BOOK	Tell the story from the Bible. **Hold your open Bible** so kids see it comes from God's Word, not a storybook you made up	8–10 min
LOOK	Look at what it means: "What does this show us about God? Where do we see Jesus?"	2–3 min
TOOK	What we "took" home: one action step for this week	1 min

Storytelling tips

- **Tell, don't read** (if you can). Learn the script well enough to look at kids' faces, and keep the open Bible in your hands.
- **Use your voice.** Whisper for secrets, go big for giants, slow down for important lines.
- **Use props.** A scarf for a robe, a flashlight for God's light, a rock for Goliath's stone.
- **Ask "What do you think happens next?"** It keeps kids leaning in.
- **Always end at Jesus.** Each phase file includes "where Jesus shows up" for every book.
- **Be truthful.** Simplify, but never change what the Bible says. If a story is hard (a flood, a battle, the cross), tell it gently and honestly, and focus on God's goodness and rescue.

Teaching by age group

Group	Do	Avoid
🐑 **Little Lambs (4–6)**	Short sentences. Repeat key lines ("God keeps His promises!"). Let them do motions and sound effects. Sit on their level. 5–7 minute story max.	Abstract words ("covenant," "redemption") without a picture. Long sitting. Scary details.
🧭 **Explorers (7–10)**	Let them read a verse aloud. Use "Who/What/Where" questions. Competition works well.	Talking down to them. Skipping the "why."
🥾 **Trailblazers (11–13)**	Give them Bibles to look things up. Use maps and timelines. Welcome hard questions.	Pat answers. Embarrassing anyone who reads slowly.
🕊️ **Ambassadors (14–17)**	Discuss, don't lecture. Connect to real life: school, friends, social media, doubt, purpose. Give them leadership.	Treating them like little kids. Ignoring doubt.

Handling hard questions

- **"I don't know, but let's find out together"** is a great answer. Write the question down and bring an answer next week.
- Point back to what we *do* know: God is good, God is loving, God keeps His promises, and Jesus is the Rescuer.

- For personal or sensitive issues (grief, abuse, family trouble), listen, comfort, and **tell the Children's Ministry Director the same day**, following church safety policy.

Part 4: How to Teach the Books of the Bible (Memory, Spelling, Reading)

The full system is in books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md. The short version:

The 5-Step Book Mastery Ladder

Every child climbs this ladder for each new book:

1. **HEAR IT:** The teacher says the book name clearly. Kids repeat it 3 times (whisper, normal, shout).
2. **SING IT:** Add it to the cumulative song with its hand motion.
3. **SEE IT:** Show the flashcard. Point to each syllable. Clap the syllables.
4. **SPELL IT:** Spell it aloud together, then alone (Explorers and up). Little Lambs name the first letter and its sound.
5. **FIND IT:** Find the book in a real Bible using the Table of Contents, then without it. Timed "Sword Drills" for older kids.

Daily memory routine (5 minutes, every Sunday)

1. **Sing** the cumulative song (all books learned so far).
2. **Section Shout:** Teacher calls a section ("LAW!"), kids shout the books in it.
3. **Missing Book:** Teacher says the list but skips one, and kids shout the missing book.
4. **Spell of the Week:** One book is spelled out loud as a group.

Spelling instruction

- **Clap the syllables:** "Deu-ter-on-o-my" = 5 claps. Spell one clap-chunk at a time.
- **Look-Say-Cover-Write-Check:** Look at the word, say it, cover it, write it, and check it. (Explorers and up.)
- **Tricky parts in a color:** Write the hard part in red: Le**v**iticus, Ecc**les**iastes, Phi**l**ippians, Thess**a**lonians.
- **Numbers:** Teach that "1 Samuel" is read "First Samuel," and the number is written as a numeral.
- **Little Lambs:** Focus on first letters and sounds ("Genesis starts with G, /g/ /g/ Genesis!"), letter tracing and finding the letter on the flashcard.

Reading instruction

- **Echo reading:** Teacher reads a line, kids echo.
- **Choral reading:** Everyone reads together.
- **Partner reading:** Older kid reads with a younger kid (great Ambassador job).
- **Never force** a struggling reader to read aloud alone. Offer "Do you want to read, or pick a friend to help?"

Part 5: How to Run Games

Full game instructions are in game-library.md, and each phase file has phase-specific games.

The Golden Rules of Games

1. **Explain in 30 seconds or less.** Demonstrate rather than describe.
2. **Everyone plays.** Avoid elimination games where kids sit out a long time. If someone is "out," give them a job (scorekeeper, judge, "question master").
3. **Learning first, winning second.** Every game must practice book names, verses or story facts.
4. **Safety:** Clear the space, no running near chairs, and soft balls only.
5. **End on a high.** Stop while kids still want more.
6. **Mixed teams.** Pair older with younger so everyone can contribute.

Teams & points

- Use the same 2–4 team names all year (e.g., Lions, Lambs, Eagles, Doves), or let kids name teams after Bible heroes.
- Keep a running **Phase Leaderboard** on a poster. Points can be traded for a team privilege (first in line for snack, choosing the game).

Part 6: How to Run Trivia

Each phase has 30+ trivia questions in three tiers.

Tier	Who	Point value
⭐ Easy	Little Lambs and Explorers	1 point
⭐⭐ Medium	Explorers and Trailblazers	2 points
⭐⭐⭐ Hard	Trailblazers and Ambassadors	3 points

Trivia formats

- **Classic Quiz Show:** Teams take turns. Teams may choose their tier, so a younger team can earn points too.
- **Buzzer Race:** Kids slap a table, ring a bell or squeeze a squeaky toy to answer.
- **Stand Up/Sit Down (True or False):** Stand for true, sit for false. Everyone plays.
- **Four Corners:** Label corners A/B/C/D, read a multiple-choice question, and kids run to their answer.
- **Trivia Ball:** Toss a beach ball with questions written on it, and the catcher answers whatever their thumb lands on.
- **Bible Bowl (Phase 12):** Year-end tournament. See Phase 12.

Tip for teachers: Read the question twice, give 10 seconds of think time, and celebrate wrong answers that show effort ("Great guess! It was actually...").

Part 7: How to Run a Spelling Bee

Use it at the end of each phase (Explorers and up) and in a big year-end bee.

1. **Word list:** From the phase's "Spelling & Reading" section. Give it to kids in Week 1.
2. **Format:** The speller stands and says the word, spells it, and says it again ("Genesis. G-E-N-E-S-I-S. Genesis.").
3. **They may ask:** for the word to be repeated, used in a sentence, or for the section it's in.
4. **Gentle rules for church:** A misspell earns a "second-chance ticket" once per bee, and spellers who are out join the "Judges' Panel" to help check spelling.
5. **Team Bee (for mixed ages):** Teams spell one letter each in a line, passing to the next person. Little Lambs can be the "first-letter starter."
6. **Prizes:** Everyone who participates earns a sticker, and the top spellers earn the phase's "Super Speller" star.

Part 8: How to Use the Videos

See the YouTube Video Guide. Key rules:

- **Always preview** the full video before class, including the end (to avoid autoplay surprises).
- **Use full screen with autoplay off.** Turn off autoplay and close comments and suggestions before class. Ads may play on YouTube. Consider downloading through an approved method or using YouTube Premium for classroom use, or show videos only after they're cued.
- **Watch with a purpose:** Give kids 1–2 "look-for" questions *before* the video ("Watch for what Moses held in his hand").
- **Pause to talk.** For BibleProject videos with younger kids, pause every 1–2 minutes and ask, "What did we just learn?"

Part 9: Classroom Management (Quick Tips)

- **Attention signal:** Teacher says "Bible!" and kids answer "Bible! Lamp unto my feet!" and freeze.
- **Clear 3 rules:** Listen when someone talks. Keep hands and feet to yourself. Be kind with words.
- **Catch kids being good:** Praise out loud, with specifics.
- **Movement every 10 minutes** for Little Lambs and Explorers (motions, stretch, "stand if...").
- **Have a "next thing" ready** for early finishers (word search, coloring, flashcards).
- **Know your kids:** Learn names in Week 1, and ask about their week.

Part 10: Volunteer Checklist

- [ ] I completed the church child-safety training and background check.
- [ ] I read the phase file for this month.
- [ ] I read the Bible passages myself.
- [ ] I previewed and queued the videos.
- [ ] I can lead the book song with motions.
- [ ] Supplies are printed and ready.
- [ ] The Take-Home Family Page went out.
- [ ] I prayed for my class.